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An independent and unconventional character: Fikriye, 'Everybody's Woman'

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ABSTRACT
Despite being a prolific and popular serial novelist of the 1920s, Selahattin Enis is an almost forgotten Ottoman/Turkish writer. *Orta Malı (Everybody's Woman)*, serialised in 1925-1926, was among his most successful novels. Despite this, it has long been excluded from the literary canon, published in Latin script only in 2017. Set in the early 1920s, *Everybody's Woman centers* on Fikriye, the novel's primary female character. Initially employed as a maid, Fikriye navigates from one mansion to another, guided by her desires. A married woman, she engages in multiple heterosexual and homosexual affairs, eventually becoming an 'outstanding prostitute'. Selahattin Enis is characterised as an 'ultra-realist' or 'naturalist', and probably intended Fikriye to serve as a symbol of societal degradation. However, Fikriye's character evolves in a manner that diverges from the author's initial intent, gaining an 'unconventional' autonomy. By 'unconventional', I refer to her existence outside dominant norms. Fikriye's development occurs in opposition to the author's heteronormative intentions. While various explanations may be offered for the belated recognition of Selahattin Enis, this paper contends that the primary cause of this oversight, particularly in the case of *Everybody's Woman*, lies in the queer characteristics of both the protagonist and the narrative.

KEYWORDS
Queer; performativity; heteronormativity; literary canon; serial novel

Introduction

Literary history and the literary canon not only shape our understanding of literature but also influence our perceptions of society, history, culture, and sexuality. Beginning with cornerstone feminist scholarship and subsequently reinforced by adjacent disciplines such as LGBT and queer theory, it is now widely acknowledged that both literary history and the literary canon are far from neutral or unbiased. A variety of reasons have been given for the exclusion of particular works and figures from the literary mainstream, including literary conventions, stylistic devices, and artistic movements, to broader socio-political and cultural shifts, not to mention market forces. Although these factors may be construed as reasonable justifications for the exclusion of certain literary works, they nonetheless serve to narrow the scope of works and figures available to both readers and researchers. Extensive studies on gender and sexuality in academia

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have shown us that one of the significant mechanisms of exclusion is simply normative, related to gender and sexuality.

Examining the transition from Ottoman to Turkish literature, one also finds the same 'conservative' and 'heteronormative' tendencies. But queer examination of Turkish literature started somewhat late, and those aspects were also recognised belatedly. In this paper, I focus on Selahattin Enis, a prominent writer of his era, and explore the reasons behind the exclusion of his novel *Everybody's Woman* from the literary canon. My main argument is that contrary to the author's intention, the protagonist Fikriye and the narrative structure of *Everybody's Woman* exhibit notable queer features, which led the novel to be struck from the literary canon and history. In making this argument, I will sketch the features that make the novel queer, despite what Selahattin Enis envisaged. Then, I will try to reposition the novel in literature and history. As *Everybody's Woman* serves as a reflection of the transitional period in Ottoman/Turkish society – encompassing shifts in literature, sexuality, politics, and culture – its examination and repositioning offer valuable opportunities to critically reassess and re-evaluate the literary landscape with which we are familiar.

Specifically, I advance a queer reading of the novel, which – as Holden (2003, 300) points out, allows us to 'locate moments of slippage in the performance of sexuality and, indeed, of gender'. In capturing and analysing the moments of 'slippages' in the novel, I will adopt Altınay's (2018, 243) conceptual framework, using 'queer' as an analytical tool 'to study the structures of feeling, practices of pleasure, and modes of identification that are 'at odds with the normal, the legitimate, the dominant' in gendered and sexualised ways' rather than 'the contemporary Western European and North American categories of sexuality'.

On the other hand, queer is not only limited to sexuality and gender, but also related to norms, margins, differences, and divergences: 'The study of norms and deviance is central to the intellectual genealogy of queer studies. [… .] [R]esearch on deviance and social problems in the social sciences, shaped queer studies' commitment to subcultures, to nonnormativity, and to a constructionist view of sexuality' (Love 2021, 136). So, *Everybody's Woman* offers the possibility to discuss both diverse sexual practices, and challenges to the class and ethnic hierarchies in a counter-normative queer perspective at the same time.

Selahattin Enis's legacy and *Everybody's Woman*, as a serial novel

Selahattin Enis (Atabeyoğlu) (1892–1942) was a popular novelist of his time, but his primary professional undertaking was as a journalist. He held significant roles across print journalism in the late Ottoman and early Republican periods. His career started at *Tanin* (*Resonance*) in 1910, and throughout his lifetime, he worked at different newspapers and journals, including *Cumhuriyet* (*Republic*), *İkdam* (*Perseverance*), *Kadın* (*Woman*), *Kaplan* (*Tiger*), *Milliyet* (*Nation*), *Payitaht* (*Capital City*), *Son Saat* (*Last Hour*), *Son Telgraf* (*Last Telegraph*), *Şebab* (*Youth*), and *Vakit* (*Time*), most of which were mainstream periodicals. Selahattin Enis published his first novel, *Neriman* [Character's name], in 1912, as well as articles and short stories that contributed to his reputation until World War I, which put a temporary hold on his journalism, and his novel-writing.

His career as a novelist took off after the war, with the publication of a range of serialised novels. In 1922, *Fitnat'ın Sergüzeşti* (*The Adventures of Fitnat*) appeared in serial

form in *İleri* (*Ahead*). *Sara* [Character's name] and *Cehennem Yolcuları* (*Passengers to Hell*) were serialised in *İkdam* in 1923 and 1924, respectively, while *Everybody's Woman*, *Ayarı Bozuklar* (*Crazy Types*), and *Endam Aynası* (*Cheval Glass*) were serialised in *Son Saat* in 1925, 1926, and 1928, respectively. Selahattin Enis's final novel, *Mahalle* (*Neighbourhood*), was serialised in *Zaman* in 1930. Of these, only *Neighbourhood* used the Latin alphabet since it came after the script reform of November 1928. This reform replaced the Ottoman Turkish alphabet, which was based on the Arabic script, with a modified version of the Latin alphabet. During the author's lifetime, only three of his novels – namely *Sara*, *Passengers to Hell*, and *The Adventures of Fitnat* (later renamed *Zaniyeler* [*Adulteress Women*]) – were published as books using the Ottoman script. Until the 2010s, only *Zaniyeler* had been transliterated into the Latin alphabet, published as a book, and made accessible to contemporary readers. However, recent years have seen a resurgence in Selahattin Enis' works: *Sara* and *Passengers to Hell* were transliterated and published in 2016, *Everybody's Woman* in 2017, and *Crazy Types* and *Cheval Glass* in 2022.

Despite being a prolific writer during the early Republican period and having his novels serialised in prestigious publications, Selahattin Enis remains a largely overlooked figure in literary history. Memoirs and eyewitness accounts confirm that he was well-connected within the literary circles of his era (Tane 2015, 32–33). Yet, curiously, most of his novels have not been transliterated into the Latin alphabet, and he is often either omitted from literary histories or included only with cursory mention. What, then, accounts for his unquestionable exclusion from the literary canon? While multiple factors are likely salient – including his naturalistic approach, which involved harsh criticism of contemporary society, his divergence from literary conventions, and even his status as a serial novelist – the case of *Everybody's Woman* stands out. Specifically, the novel's exclusion can be attributed to its failure to align with canonical values, the absence of nationalist themes, its lack of emphasis on Republican values, and most significantly, its queer characters and narration.

Son Saat – where *Everybody's Woman* was serialised – was a well-known newspaper of the period with wide circulation. Serialisation of the novel – which appeared in 156 instalments – began on 29 December 1925 and ended on 2 July 1926. Measured by number of instalments, it is one of the longest serial novels unearthed by the project 'History of the Serial Novel in Turkish Literature (1830–1928)'.[1] This extensive serialisation serves as an indicator of the novel's popularity and readership at the time. For context, less popular novels of that era would seldom exceed 50 instalments. Much like today's television series, the length of a serial novel during this period was largely contingent upon reader demand. Features that are inherent to the genre of the serial novel offers the author considerable flexibility. By incorporating new plot elements into the existing storyline, the author can modify the narrative, which Couégnas (2006, 330) refers to as 'plasticity': '[T]he serialised novel, a finely calibrated cultural product subject to the reactions of its reader, possesses great plasticity: if unsuccessful,

[1]The project was conducted between 2014–2017 and supported by TÜBİTAK (Scientific and Technological Research Council of Turkey) (project number 113K497). The project website is available at: http://tefrikaroman.ozyegin.edu.tr/ANASAYFA?lang=en. The serial novels found in the project have been uploaded to a digital archive available at: https://hdl.handle.net/10679/888. For a more detailed analysis of the serial novels, readers may refer to the works of Serdar and Tutumlu published in 2019 and 2022.

it can be moved quickly to its conclusion; if successful, it can be prolonged indefinitely'. Another option the author can implement is to add new interconnected storylines to structure a narrative in more complex but also fluid ways, which is called 'multiplicity' by O'Sullivan (2019, 54). As it turns out, in *Everybody's Woman*, these features of 'plasticity' and 'multiplicity' – reflected in the addition of new subplots, characters, challenges, and resolutions, often facilitated by coincidental events – also underpins its queer narrative. As stated by O'Sullivan, the features used in a serial 'shape the frames and effects by which we make narrative meaning of serials' (57). So, it can be asserted that while adding those new characters, new sublots, and creating 'the dynamic storytelling relationship between one serial episode and another', which is called 'momentum' by O'Sullivan (55), Selahhatin Enis loses his control over the character, Fikriye evades from the intended limits.

The central storyline of *Everybody's Woman* fits within the framework of the 'hero's journey', a narrative archetype that has been present in literature since the time of *Odysseus*. In this novel, readers follow the adventures of Fikriye, a young woman in her early 20s. Prompted by her mother Hayriye Hanım – herself about to marry for the fourth time – Fikriye weds İshak Effendi, an older, retired man who falls short of satisfying her sexual needs. Ostensibly to contribute to the household expenses, Fikriye soon persuades her husband – a notorious miser – to let her look for a job. She then secures employment as a maid in Necmi Bey's mansion, marking the beginning of her journey. Subsequently, she moves through a series of residences: first to the home of Celile Hanım, Necmi Bey's sister; then to the estate of Zertaç Hanım, a close friend of Celile Hanım. After some time, she moves on to the home of Sedat, Zertaç Hanım's former lover; finally, she finds apartments of her own, initially in Taksim and later in Şişli. The narrative is set in post-World War I Istanbul and likely precedes the proclamation of the Republic (in October 1923), as it includes harsh criticisms of war profiteers but offers scant references to the national war of independence (1918–1922) or the Republican regime.

Fikriye as a performative character

Throughout her journey, Fikriye finds employment with various individuals, encountering new people at each juncture. Characterised by the narrator as possessing an insatiable sexual appetite, Fikriye engages in a wide array of sexual relationships. In analysing Fikriye's journey, I first sketch these relationships to establish the scope of her interactions. Subsequently, I will delve into the motivations for her actions as portrayed by the narrator. Finally, I will highlight the incongruities in the author's characterisation that contribute to the formation of a queer character.

Soon after starting as a maid at Necmi Bey's residence, Fikriye strikes up a clandestine affair with Ecvet Bey, her employer's married son. To make matters worse, the old man has developed feelings for Fikriye. Just as the infatuated patriarch contemplates declaring his undying love for Fikriye, he uncovers the affair and banishes her from the house. Fortunately, Necmi Bey's sister, Celile Hanım, takes pity on her and offers to take her in. Celile, a lesbian, is captivated by Fikriye. After moving to Celile Hanım's mansion Fikriye navigates intimate encounters with Celile and her female companions Şükran, Perran, and Peyman (about whom we

will learn more later). Never one to stand still, Fikriye soon moves on, this time to the home of Zertaç Hanım, a close associate of Celile, who asks Fikriye to move in to take care of her supposed husband, Ferdi Bey. True to form, Fikriye has sexual relations with him too.

After some time, Fikriye grows bored of her life in Zertaç Hanım's house. Out and about one day, she encounters an acquaintance, Sedat, who happens to be an ex-lover of Zertaç Hanım and accepts an invitation to move in with him. With Sedat, Fikriye leads a happy life as his live-in mistress. Tragically, Sedat falls ill and dies. Fikriye continues to visit her own home sporadically to care for her husband, İshak Effendi, cooking for him and tending to his needs. She is unwilling to move back in permanently following Sedat's untimely demise, so she returns to home. Before long, she embarks on a surreptitious liaison one night with Çakmak Aziz, her mother's fourth husband.

At a loss following Sedat's death, she hesitates about returning to Zertaç Hanım's home and feels unsure about her next steps. By a stroke of luck, she chances upon Harun Pasha, whose acquaintance she made at Zertaç Hanım's house. Together, they head to an establishment run by Madam Anjel, a notorious bordello. In a state of restless dissatisfaction, Harun Pasha, a man who has traversed the spectrum of sexual relationships and identifies as bisexual, finds himself yearning for something novel: women's accessories and shoes (he also has a foot fetish). Thus, Fikriye is introduced to her first fetish encounter. Fikriye also earns her first payment for sex, as Harun Pasha leaves a little money on the nightstand.

Madam Anjel offers Fikriye a place in her bordello and a share in the business. She first seduces Abdülgaffur Bey, a wealthy man with a penchant for virgins. Feigning youthful innocence and virginity, Fikriye earns 400 liras for her deception. Under Madam Anjel's close tutelage, Fikriye then seduces another wealthy paramour, Süleyman Effendi. As Fikriye's reputation as a sought-after courtesan grows, she leaves Madam Anjel's establishment and strikes out on her own, renting premises first in Taksim and later in Şişli. Her final named client is Hasan bin el-Berîd, a wealthy Egyptian. Although the narrator never discloses their names, her subsequent encounters as a courtesan are numerous – sometimes as many as three in a single day (Selahattin Enis 2017, 270).

The sheer volume and diversity of Fikriye's sexual relationships are staggering, eclipsing any comparative figures in Ottoman/Turkish literature. Readers were no doubt astounded with the sheer number of her sexual dalliances; no other male, much less female, character in the literary canon can match the range of her encounters.[2] When it comes to the diversity of these relations – including heterosexual, homosexual, and fetishistic experiences – Fikriye stands in a category of her own.

This observation naturally prompts inquiry into why Selahattin Enis would craft such a character of sexual excess in 1925 and serialise her exploits in a widely-read daily newspaper. Two contrasting interpretations emerge in response to this question: the first pertains to the author's intended crafting of Fikriye, while the second centres on the character's queer traits that not only elude but also actively subvert heteronormative expectations.

[2]The possible exceptions are the female characters of Hüseyin Rahmi Gürpınar (1864–1944). It is no coincidence that Gürpınar comes to mind since his female characters are also very active figures in terms of sexuality (see, e.g. Moran 1999; Serdar 2007). Still, even these women can scarcely catch Fikriye. For a queer reading of Gürpınar's works, see Altınay (2018) and Şahinler (2021).

From the beginning of the novel, Fikriye is portrayed as a character with an innate 'extreme desire' for erotic encounters. This desire manifests as she matures, leading her to seduce young men in the neighbourhood, much to the chagrin of locals. Her mother, Hayriye Hanım, is not blind to her daughter's impulsive sexuality and at times finds it difficult to rein her in:

> In fact, she sees that her daughter has become a kind of a troublemaker. Driven by her intense lust and ambition, she becomes unmoored, and her eyes sparkle at the mere glimpse of a man or the sound of a masculine voice.[3] (20).

Indeed, Hayriye Hanım's choice to wed Fikriye to the ageing İshak Effendi reveals her underlying anxieties that her daughter could tempt her own fiancé (who would become her fourth husband) (20), a prescient suspicion, as it turns out.

In fact, the narrator is at pains to emphasise that Fikriye's insatiable desires are not mere whims but are, in fact, rooted in her genetic makeup, inherited from both her mother, Hayriye Hanım, and her father, Misbah Effendi (her mother's third husband). In sketching the dynamics between her parents, the narrator highlights this inherited predisposition, ascribing Fikriye's inclinations to her genetic inheritance:

> The reverie soon moves to the bedroom. Here, Misbah Effendi transforms into a man of a different character. Though he is aged 40, his virility rivals that of a man half his age […] In his sexual frenzy, he disregards all restraint, whether rooted in religious obligation or his wife's physical well-being. Hayriye Hanım is like a cork; he, a corkscrew. They seem impervious to exhaustion. […] Fikriye is the product of such nights and such parents. The blood of a coquette mother and a father resembling a human stud animal run in her veins. (17)

This kind of biological determinism reflects Selahattin Enis's literary style – that is, his naturalism – but assigning determined sexual identities is also an attitude of heteronormativity (Halperin 2013, 94), one the author eagerly embraces. A deterministic view assumes static, stable, unchanging behaviour and identity; and as a conclusion, in Fikriye's case, authorial authority, represented either in the narrator's voice and choices, or in the organisation of plot, manipulates the reader to think that Fikriye's acts and identity are determined from the beginning, she has no chance to change them. However, rather than a structured and overdetermined understanding of identity, especially related with sex and gender, a queer understanding should be more relevant for Fikriye's case. As Judith Butler (1999) argued in *Gender Trouble*, gender is not a given stable identity, it is constituted in time by repeated acts:

> Gender ought not to be construed as a stable identity or locus of agency from which various acts follow; rather, gender is an identity tenuously constituted in time, instituted in an exterior space through a *stylized repetition of acts*. The effect of gender is produced through the stylization of the body and, hence, must be understood as the mundane way in which bodily gestures, movements, and styles of various kinds constitute the illusion of an abiding gendered self. This formulation moves the conception of gender off the ground of a substantial model of identity to one that requires a conception of gender as a constituted *social temporality*. (179, emphasizes are original)

So, by claiming sexuality and sexual identities as static and unchanging, heteronormativity produces inherent contradictions. Moreover, trying to keep Fikriye within the

[3]All translations of the original Turkish are my own.

limits of heteronormativity multiplies these contradictions. For example, according to the narrator's perspective, Fikriye's understanding of love is portrayed as fundamentally at odds with traditional, heteronormative conceptions of romance. Guided by her intrinsic predispositions, she views love through a materialistic lens, reducing it to mere corporeal sensations and biological impulses rather than embracing the emotional or spiritual dimensions often ascribed to romantic love: 'She does not know such things like love or passion. Fikriye is taken aback when she learns of individuals so consumed by love that they take their own lives. In her opinion, love is only sexual relations, only the pleasure of sense and skin' (Selahattin Enis 2017, 70). While narrator enforces the reader to interpret Fikriye as a depraved woman and arouses antipathy against her, as the plot moves on Fikriye becomes an independent character, acting against the normative limits. This characterisation challenges the normative standards of love and relationships, reflecting the complex interplay of nature, nurture, and societal expectations in shaping Fikriye's worldview. As will be shown, Fikriye gains her identity through dynamic relations; she is always acting and performing, which recalls Butler's view of gender. In *Gender Trouble* Butler (1999), draws attention to the close relationship between act and gender identity:

> In what senses, then, is gender an act? As in other ritual social dramas, the action of gender requires a performance that is *repeated.* This repetition is at once a reenactment and reexperiencing of a set of meanings already socially established; and it is the mundane and ritualized form of their legitimation. (178)

Following Butler's view quoted above, Dalmasso (2020) asserts that:

> There is no 'inner' or 'authentic' sexual identity, because identity is itself performative, it is an illusory fabrication manufactured through corporeal signs and discursive means, and so it is every gendered gesture, act or conduct that concurs to construct it. Gender is what emerges through the reiteration of such performances, not in the sense of a simple assumption of a role to be played, but as a repetition … (163)

So, I suggest what is observed in Fikriye's case thus is a performative sense of sexuality. Her desire, her acts determine her sexuality. This performativity also leads to a queer understanding of sexuality, as defined by Altınay (2015, 90): 'Queer here refers to an analytical tool to study the embodied practices, structures of feeling, and modes of identification that are "at odds with the normal, the legitimate, the dominant" in ways that are intrinsically related to gender and sexuality'.

Indeed, Fikriye's performative approach to sexuality serves to complicate Selahattin Enis's deterministic framework. One of her most notable traits is her ceaseless pursuit of change and novelty. She has little interest in stability or routine, forever seeking new experiences to disrupt the monotony. This restlessness challenges the notion that her behaviour is merely the product of genetic or social determinism:

> The defining aspect of her character is her craving for variety. For Fikriye, all must be in flux: her surroundings, her social circle, the settings she finds herself in – everything in her life must perpetually evolve. Her primary source of pleasure resides in her engagement with an ever-changing tapestry of experiences. (Selahattin Enis 2017, 70).

This ceaseless desire for novelty serves as a key counterpoint to the deterministic framing of her character, a *queer tendency* that violates the boundaries of heteronormativity.

Though wedded herself, she seduces several married men, including Ecvet Bey, Ferdi Bey, and Sedat Bey, all 'adulterous' encounters from a heteronormative perspective. Moreover, while she has lesbian relations in Celile Hanım's mansion, her devotion to change is most evident: 'For someone whose disposition and character lean towards men, love between women represents uncharted territory. Yet, her inherently diverse nature, craving distinct experiences in personality, pleasure, and passion, yearns for a unique flavour even in this realm' (76). Despite later admitting to herself that she is not fond of the lesbian love she experiences at the mansion (109), she deems it necessary to move in with Zertaç Hanım as a means of satisfying her unquenchable thirst for change: 'It is necessary to get out of this limited space and walk towards a new horizon' (109).

At this point let me remark on the close relationship between Fikriye's desire with the narrative flow. Peter Brooks (1992, 37), mentions the 'narrative desire' by which the plot finds its way and the reader keeps reading on: 'We can, then, conceive of the reading of plot as a form of desire that carries us forward, onward, through the text'. Desire makes narrative move forward, and as Brooks states, for example, the characters of Balzac like Rastignac, Lucien de Rubempré are 'bundle[s] of appetencies that will motivate and animate the plot of his novels' (43). So specific forms of human desire come to be the motor forces of the novel's plot. In *Everybody's Woman*, it is Fikriye's desire that produces the basic energy that carries on the plot, moves it forward. And when it comes to a serial novel, this desire becomes more energetic and more fluid.[4] When Fikriye enters Celile Hanım's mansion, a new substory and new characters are articulated into the narrative, and the plot achieves a new space and temporality; features of 'multiplicity' and 'momentum' are at work (O'Sullivan 2019); on the other hand, Fikriye's character gains new features as well. Fikriye shifts to a new substory by moving to Zertaç Hanım's house, whom she meets in Celile Hanım's mansion, and a set of new characters, Sedat, Harun Pasha, and Neyzen, enter her life and will soon affect her character. So, with each substory, each character, a new cliffhanger, or a suspense is added to the plot, by which curiosity is aroused and the fixed identity initially attributed to Fikriye is disrupted.

The same tendency for novelty can also be observed in Fikriye's encounter with Harun Pasha. When Fikriye bumps into him in Taksim, her feelings about him are positive – she finds him a little bit old but an elegant man (Selahattin Enis 2017, 199) and accepts his rather indecent proposal. Once again, her curiosity and desire drive her. At the end of the night, she finds what she experiences a little bit 'weird' (205) because Harun Pasha satisfies his desires with Fikriye's feet and shoes, but she feels no regret. Instead, she is glad of the new opportunities afforded by entry into Harun Pasha's milieu. So, from another perspective, Fikriye's sexuality, which depends on performativity, not only subverts Selahattin Enis's determinism but also, as a fictional character, she performs against the author's will. As Judith Butler (1993) states in 'Critically Queer':

[4]Brooks (1992), in Chapter 6 'The Mark of the Beast: Prostitution, Serialization, and Narrative', examines Eugène Sue's *Les Mystères de Paris* and Emilé Zola's *Nana* and as the title demonstrates discusses the relationship between serialisation and narrative, and how prostitution reflected in the nineteenth century novel as one of the popular issues of time. I am aware that Selahattin Enis and Zola as authors; Fikriye and Nana as characters; and serialisation and prostitution as issues also related to my study, have close affinities. However, Brooks' perspective, especially discussing the issue of prostitution is not convenient with the queer perspective I am adopting in this article. And since my aim is not to get into a debate with Brooks, I purposely do not refer to the ideas reflected in the mentioned chapter.

> The effects of performatives, understood as discursive productions, they do not conclude at the terminus of a given statement or utterance, the passing of legislation, the announcement of a birth. The reach of their signifiability cannot be controlled by the one who utters or writes, since such productions are not owned by the one who utters them. They continue to signify in spite of their authors, and sometimes against their authors' most precious intentions. (241)

In the last instance, Fikriye is a discursive product, a fictional character, composed of words, attributed by the author. While Selahattin Enis endeavours to portray Fikriye as a woman driven by overpowering genetic impulses, and despite his intention to cast her as a seductive and adulterous figure according to the prevailing social conventions, her performative nature transcends these confines.

Some of Fikriye's acts that violate the author's will can also be observed in terms of social critique. However, before delving into this matter, it is crucial to underscore that in *Everybody's Woman*, queer desire is not confined solely to Fikriye; it permeates the narrative, emerging through the interactions of several characters.

Homosocial culture: gay and lesbian love in *Everybody's Woman*

Recent academic studies from diverse disciplines have illuminated the fact that the broader culture of Ottoman society encompassed homoerotic and homosocial elements. These facets of culture found expression not only in literary works but also in different narratives like memois or medical texts (Andrews and Kalpaklı 2004; Kuru 2011; Sarıtaş 2018; Ze'evi 2005, 2006). Droor Ze'evi (2005, 36), in his article focuses on 'three major loci of Middle Eastern cultural production that have had a deep impact on society: medical texts, theater plays, and erotic literature', and argues that the sexual discourse reflected in these fields was transformed during the nineteenth century: 'sexual discourse moved out of the textual sphere and into the arena of male and female intimate circles, while a curtain of silence descended on the text-bound sexual stage' (50). Ezgi Sarıtaş (2018, 45–46), following Ze'evi's ideas, notes that homoerotic and homosocial features in Ottoman society disappeared and transformed into a heteronormative culture during the modernisation process, especially after the nineteenth century. From another perspective, the literary historian Selim Sırrı Kuru (2011, 276) observes that before the Republican period, stories about beloved men could be found in oral and written culture but disappeared after the 1920s. In *Everybody's Woman*, queer characters from traditional as well as 'contemporary' homosocial culture infiltrate the novel and contribute to its queer narrative.

As mentioned above, Harun Pasha is one of *Everybody's Woman*'s queer characters. Although the narrator calls him a 'cuckold' (Selahattin Enis 2017, 153) when he first appears in Zertaç Hanım's house, he is later cast in a more 'neutral' way as a person who has different relations in his life. In that sense, he resembles Fikriye in terms of their shared passion for change:

> Pasha is a person worth examining in terms of his mental state. He has gone through various phases of intense passions, nurturing profound affections for numerous women of diverse backgrounds and nationalities over the course of many years. However, there came a point when he could no longer derive satisfaction from these experiences. Instead, he embarked on a journey of homosexual love, closing the doors of his heart to women for an extended

> period, which led to a series of erotic adventures. Since Pasha always goes to extremes in his desires and passions, he often tires of one pleasure, quickly replacing it with another. In this respect, it can be said that Pasha's passions change their identity from year to year and go towards their origin and extinction. However, object worship remains a deeply ingrained mental affliction, a testament to its enduring presence in his life. For Harun Pasha, being in the presence of items of well-used women's clothing serve as a substitute for physical contact, allowing him to experience something of the pleasure of sexual relations with a woman. (204)

Another queer figure is Nafiz Effendi, the second husband of Hayriye Hanım, who is described as 'flirtatious' (14). A while after they married, Nafiz Effendi comes home with 'four eyebrowed' young boys (meaning their moustaches are newly grown), whom he introduced to Hayriye Hanım as his relatives. From the narrator's allusions, the reader senses Nafiz Effendi's sexual tendencies. Some time later, Hayriye Hanım busts Nafiz Effendi with another young boy in an 'improper' state (15) and promptly divorces him. Thus, Nafiz Effendi transgresses heteronormative culture and, as a queer figure, participates in the homosocial culture of Ottoman/Turkish society.

Rıfat Effendi, another figure within the homosocial culture, is in Platonic love with Hristo, a barkeeper. He is seen only in the scene where Fikriye's husband, İshak Effendi and Hayriye Hanım's husband, Çakmak Aziz, visit the Eminönü district and drop into Soysuz Dimtri's tavern in Balıkpazarı. Intriguingly, in this scene, we not only see the homosocial aspects but also the multicultural life of 1920s Istanbul reflected. Since İshak Effendi is not familiar with tavern life, the visit is depicted from his point of view: 'He sees that taverns are truly a world unto themselves and the barkeeper's counter is a place where all kinds of temperaments and identities are gathered' (92). When İshak Effendi and Çakmak Aziz enter the basement, they encounter virtually the entire ethnic structure of Ottoman society: 'A Persian is seated beside a Laz, while a Kurd is talking to an Armenian' (93). This attitude of grasping the multiethnic structure of society, embracing the marginal, and 'miscellaneous forms of difference' (Love 2021, 136) is also compatible with what the field of queer studies is search for. And if it is considered in a broader sense, taking out the years of the novel's serialisation, it is hard to find this kind of 'multiethnic scene' in literature, especially in a period when national literature was on the rise. This attitude of representing diversity, seems unconventional and counter-normative, and makes narrative queer.

Moreover, in this tavern scene, the narrator, in addition to vividly portraying the cosmopolitan atmosphere of Istanbul, also hints at the presence of homosexual culture: 'Some of the customers are addicted to the raki of these taverns, some to their barkeepers, and some to the appetisers made by barkeepers' (Selahattin Enis 2017, 92). As Sarıtaş (2018) points out, taverns were significant spaces of homoerotic and homosocial encounters, where men interacted and socialised:

> Taverns, as places of drinking, music, dance and love, have a place both in Ottoman classical literature and in narratives of daily life. Until the second half of the nineteenth century, taverns, where women rarely entered, were important venues for erotic interactions between adult men and young boys. (82)

Rıfat Effendi attends Soysuz Dimitri's tavern regularly (indeed, he has been coming nearly every day for fifteen years) just to see Hristo, a barkeeper, who was 20 years old

when he started his apprenticeship in the tavern. 'The interesting part is that despite the widespread knowledge of this matter, Rıfat Effendi continues to believe that no one else was aware of his fifteen-year affection for Hristo' (Selahattin Enis 2017, 94). Thus, Rıfat Effendi is also part of the homosocial culture shared and experienced in taverns, and this queer culture is reflected in *Everybody's Woman*'s fictional world. This representation in *Everybody's Woman* is particularly significant in light of the author's intention, which is to convey social degeneration in the period.

In her study on sexual modernity in the late Ottoman and Republican periods, Sarıtaş (2018, 45–46) discusses the transformation of the homoerotic and homosocial culture of Ottoman society transitioning towards a more heteronormative one. This transformation unfolded gradually over a lengthy period but culminated at the end of the nineteenth century. To comprehend this transformation, Sarıtaş examines various sources, including literature, with novels serving as a prominent resource: 'As the nineteenth century unfolded, prose narratives supplanted verse narratives as the primary form of literary storytelling. Notably, the novel emerged as a pivotal cultural instrument in shaping conceptions of desire, emotion, gender, and family' (33). Sarıtaş's approach is legitimate since literature is one of the most fertile areas for discussing Turkish modernisation. And from Westernisation to nationalism, women's rights to education, and rural transformation to alienation, many issues across a range of scholarly disciplines have been examined through novels. Since her object of study concerns sexuality, Sarıtaş examined novels in terms of love relations. She states that the novel is the dominant form of narrative that heteroeroticised love relations (230). Hence,

> The strengthening of discourses on nuclear family and friendship-based marriage in the second half of the nineteenth century played a fundamental role in the construction of late Ottoman heteronormative fictions of love and sexuality […]. With the emergence of friendship-based marriage, heterosexuality has been institutionalised and different forms of eroticism, especially homosexual eroticism, have been overshadowed. (231)

That is why Sarıtaş claims that nineteenth-century prose love narratives (especially early Ottoman novels) offer a suitable space for analysing heteronormative frameworks (230). Referring to the work of Kuru (2011), Sarıtaş asserts that while we are talking about a transformation from homosocial to heterosocial culture, we also necessarily refer to a transformation of genres in Ottoman Turkish literature (33). By 'transformation of genres', we mean that in traditional Ottoman literature – especially in classic poetry – homosexual love could be expressed manifestly (Andrews and Kalpaklı 2004; Kuru 2006), but with modernisation, especially after the emergence of Tanzimat literature in the mid-nineteenth century, homosexual references gradually faded for the reasons Sarıtaş recounts. Kuru (2011, 276) is clear on that point: 'As a matter of fact, in virtually none of the early Turkish novels after the second half of the nineteenth century, passionate relations between men are not narrated'. Kuru's claim may be correct when only canonical texts are taken into consideration. As I previously emphasised, *Everybody's Woman*, as a non-canonical novel, stands as an exception, deviating from the norm and embracing a queer narrative through its characters and narration.

As previously mentioned, *Everybody's Woman* explores lesbian love and characters within its narrative, with a particular focus on Celile Hanım and her companions, Şükran, Perran, and Peyman. Celile Hanım's residence subverts the heterosexual

hegemonic lifestyle with its homosocial atmosphere, which I will discuss in a short while. It is worth noting that just as male homosexual characters are present in the narrative, lesbian characters also appear throughout. For instance, Fikriye's neighbours in Taksim have two daughters, Jale and Piyale, who lead contrasting lives dominated by opposing preferences. Jale, who dislikes men, attends an English school, while Piyale, who dislikes women, attends a French lycée. Their circle of friends further reflects the queer culture: 'Some evenings, strange men; and girls with collars, neckties, and hair shaved like men visit their home. The girls with neckties are Jale's friends' (Selahattin Enis 2017, 269). This scene is short, yet it reflects the cross-dressing culture of the youth of the period and may represents a facet of modern culture. Of course, this representation of cross-dressed culture can also be interpreted as an anxiety about social degeneration, which can also be seen in the portrayal of many characters in the novel, like Rıfat Effendi, Harun Pasha, and especially Fikriye. It is clear that the author's perception, and representation of cross-dressing is completely different, and moreover opposite to some queer theorists' approaches, which see in cross-dressing a challenge to classic gender formation and a potential for liberation: '*In imitating gender, drag implicitly reveals the imitative structure of gender itself – as well as its contingency*' (Butler 1999, 175, emphasis original). But these unintentional 'slippages' in the narration (Holden 2003, 300), lead to 'unintended consequences' (Giddens 1996, 44) and gives the novel its queer character also.

Another lesbian figure is Sabire Hanım, who is married to İmanettin Effendi (Selahattin Enis 2017, 101) but has been in love with Celile Hanım since their youth. Şükran, one of Celile's companions, describes Sabire as Celile's 'first love', and she adds that the nights that Sabire Hanım visited the mansion were the most cheerful for the old matron (105). Strangely enough, there can be little doubt that the narration of their intimate homosexual love, which was 'witnessed and told by the moon', is one of the most vivid descriptions of two lovers in Turkish literature (103–104).

As mentioned earlier, in Turkish literature, love between men had gradually become less prominent and was rarely explored in novels. However, there was a surprising surge in narratives about lesbian love at the end of the nineteenth and the beginning of the twentieth century (Sarıtaş 2018, 308). This increase was attributed to a relatively more liberated atmosphere following the proclamation of the second constitutional monarchy in 1908. During this period, numerous erotic novels and stories were published (243). However, it is essential to note that while 'male homoeroticism was not the subject of erotic literature, female homoeroticism [… was] narrated in a way that provoked male erotic desire' (246). In other words, lesbian love was mostly narrated to satisfy male narcissism and glorify male dominance (Karahan-Richardson 2011, 153). And although the traditional sexual discourse, which was comprised of homoerotic aspects, was transformed through the nineteenth century, it seemed the male dominant core was still preserved in that case, because as Ze'evi (2006, 167) mentions: 'Although some of this discourse was attuned to the needs and sexual preferences of women, it was a singularly male voice'. This time it was represented within a heteronormative standpoint. Once again, *Everybody's Woman* and the lesbian love narrated in it buck the general trend. In examining Recaizade Mahmut Ekrem's *Saime* [Character's name], Ahmet Rasim's *Hamamcı Ülfet* (*Bath Attendant Ülfet*), and Mahmut Şevket Esendal's *Miras* (*Heritage*), Sarıtaş (2018, 320) notes how, in those narratives, 'female homoeroticism [is] seen as an

institutional social structure, not as a temporary bond' and challenges masculine privilege and phallic power, while being positioned against friendship-based marriage (308), which is a real threat to heteronormative culture. In that sense, *Everybody's Woman* has some common features with these narratives. However, especially when it comes to the narration of life in Celile Hanım's mansion, a different world – one that depends on equality and friendship – is brought into sharp relief.

Celile Hanım's description and her attitudes come close to heteronormative expectancy: 'She is a weird, strange [queer], masculinised woman' (Selahattin Enis 2017, 58). She wears collars and neckties like a man. In her residence, where men are forbidden to enter, Celile Hanım breaks away from the expectations of heteronormativity. She defies the prevailing heteronormative, hierarchical relationships and instead establishes an egalitarian world based on mutual equality and friendship. When Fikriye enters her mansion, Celile Hanım introduces her partners as her sisters: 'And pointing to the girls sitting opposite her, she adds: These are all your sisters: Perran, Peyman, Şükran […]. These are the three corners of my heart. You also fill the fourth corner' (74). And Celile Hanım recounts the lifestyle in her mansion as follows:

> In this house, formality, hypocrisy, sorrow, and pain are never allowed to cross the threshold. Only pleasure, amusement, and laughter find their place within these walls. You'll notice there are no maids in the mansion. We, Perran, Peyman, Şükran, and I, serve as both the mistress and the maid of this house. For instance, while Perran tidies up the sofa, Peyman sets the table, Şükran cleans the surfaces, and I take care of the birds. (75)

By giving Fikriye a new name, Şadan, they symbolise the fresh start she has embarked upon in entering the mansion. It doesn't take long for Fikriye to realise that Celile Hanım has established a communal life where everyone in the house is bound together as equals. As the quote above underscores, they work together, have fun together, and share their love freely. Additionally, Fikriye comes to understand that life in Celile Hanım's house is classless – there is no real 'lady of the house' and no servants. A distinct equality is thus obtained in the household. Therefore, this communal life at Celile Hanım's mansion contradicts with heteronormative household patterns and gives a queer character to the novel.

On the other hand, Celile Hanım's mansion recalls the concept of 'friendship' also. As Love (2007, 75) notes, although the concept of friendship initially emerged from feminist critique in the 1970s, it has also gained prominence as a central concept in queer studies, particularly following the influence of Michel Foucault. Love argues that, Foucault 'invoked friendship as an alternative form of intimacy, a utopian space beyond the constraints of marriage and the family' (76). The non-hierarchical relationship of women in the mansion represents equalitarian way of life as friends.

Yet while Celile Hanım at first underscores the friendship of sisterhood in the mansion, the household lifestyle exceeds its limits by embracing sexuality and labour, indeed a virtually communal lifestyle: 'The motto of my mansion is hand in hand in work, unity of love in living' (Selahattin Enis 2017, 78).

In this social milieu, discourses on the nuclear family and marriage based on friendship were getting stronger (Sarıtaş 2018, 231). Furthermore, considering that novels were often employed as a genre to reinforce family relationships following heteronormative

standards (33), Celile Hanım and her mansion pose a significant challenge and disruption to the prevailing culture. Therefore, it could be argued that, similar to male homosexual relationships, the portrayal of lesbian relationships in *Everybody's Woman* is one of the factors contributing to its exclusion from the literary canon.

Social criticism and the literary canon

As mentioned, Selahattin Enis is considered a naturalist writer (Gündüz 1987; Tane 2015) and *Everybody's Woman* narrates an explicit and harsh social criticism of Ottoman/Turkish society especially the upper classes. The events unfolding in the households of Celile Hanım and Zertaç Hanım are evident examples of this alternative lifestyle. These critiques mainly target the consumption patterns and relationships of the upper classes and war profiteers. The most direct criticism of this lifestyle comes from the character Neyzen.[5] He initially appears in Zertaç Hanım's house, introduced as the 'great tramp' (Selahattin Enis 2017, 157), due to his down at heels appearance. But the haunting melody of the ney, a kind of flute popular in the Middle East, he plays that night shocks everyone in the house (162–163). Later on, Fikriye encounters him by chance in a tramcar in Beyazıt (221) and spends the night as his guest in his modest dwelling. That night, Neyzen shares his thoughts with Fikriye and, unlike the other men and women she encounters in the novel, he focuses on the effects of World War I, social divisions, the rapacious and cynical behaviour of war profiteers, and the conditions of the impoverished classes. His observations are straightforward, and his suggestions are quite severe:

> You can see people here who, just yesterday, were driving around in the cars of occupying army officers, welcoming them into their homes and saloons without reservation. Today, they have the audacity to speak loudly about patriotism and the nation, their voices drowning out even those of war veterans who have lost their limbs. I have a deep affection for this city, this humble city, Ms. Şadan [Fikriye]. But in my opinion, a cylinder weighing thousands of tonnes should pass over this city, its hills, mansions, and apartments, and raze them to the ground. Until those who are not the real sons of the city […] are buried in the ground along with their superficial, cosmopolitan environment. This is not the real Istanbul, I tell you, Ms. Şadan! Although the war closed thousands of doors and extinguished thousands of kitchen hearths in this city, nothing of this great trouble, this epic disaster, not even a hint of it, passed through the cursed doors of these war profiteers. While thousands of our youth and Turkish villagers were dying on the borders and thousands more were starving and dying like flies on the pavements, far from being a part of the mourning of the country, they only knew how to fill their wallets. (227–228)

Neyzen also warns Fikriye about her social environment, advising her to keep her distance. However, Fikriye does not heed this advice. In fact, Fikriye has no choice, as Selahattin Enis compels her, essentially a working-class woman, to play a role instrumental in illustrating and portraying societal decadence. In this sense, Fikriye is depicted as a member of the modern, disordered society that deviates from the norm:

[5]The character of 'Neyzen' in fact refers to a real person, Neyzen Tevfik (1880–1953), who was a ney musician and poet, but more importantly, a master of satire and friend of Selahattin Enis. Their friendship is mentioned by Selahattin Enis's son Cem Atabeyoğlu in an article (n.d.) titled 'Geçmişin Ölümsüz Kişileri: Neyzen Tevfik' (The Immortal Persona of Past: Neyzen Tevfik).

> She, in every sense, embodies the archetype of a twentieth-century woman; in her perspective, concepts of morality and sanctity hold no sway. To her, life is confined to meeting basic needs like sustenance and clothing, guided only by her conscience. Life, to her, is a continuous current, and she, a piece of flotsam drifting along with it. She goes wherever the current leads, devoid of notions of family and domestic contentment. This has been her life's course, and she expects it to remain so. (208)

The framework ('morality', 'family', 'conscience') sketched here by the narrator is evidently highly normative. And the decadence of Fikriye as a member of Ottoman / Turkish society is probably related or attributed to the conditions of the postwar period. However, Fikriye also does not fit the norms of the newly established Kemalist regime:

> The 'Kemalist woman' as a subject position was defined at the intersection of multiple and conflicting roles. The ideal female citizen was to be a properly trained mother and wife, an educated professional at work, a socially active woman involved in clubs and associations, and a feminine woman dancing at balls. While fulfilling these duties, women also had to adhere to the codes of respectability and honor (namus) (Altınay 2018, 248)

In this sense, Fikriye naturally transgresses the norms of her time. Furthermore, her performance, her acts in every and each episode of the novel subverts the presumed heteronormativity the author seeks to reinforce. A closer look at Fikriye's acts casts significant doubt over the narrator's assessments, calling them into question.

As stated before, Harun Pasha is the first person to give money to Fikriye in exchange for sex, although it is not Fikriye's intention. After cooperating with Madam Anjel, this practice becomes habitual, even professional. Her first two customers, Abdülgaffur Bey and Süleyman Effendi are both part of the decadent upper classes Neyzen and the narrator condemn for amassing wealth at the expense of the broader community. By professing to be a virgin, working-class Fikriye cheats both of them, amassing her own tidy sum in the process. This is some kind of punishment for those classes. While deviating from societal norms regarding sexuality, she has demonstrated through these actions that she possesses a sense of social justice, contrary to the author's manipulations and intentions.

Fikriye's relationship with her husband, İshak Effendi, also contradicts the author's intentions. Although, as a married woman, she systematically deceives İshak Effendi, lying to his face several times, she never breaks off the marriage. Well aware of her husband's miserly ways, she goes out making money through prostitution to provide for his basic needs, eventually even buying him new clothes. An accidental encounter where she witnesses İshak Effendi being treated unjustly stirs feelings of pity and sorrow in her for her husband, emotions that are typically foreign to her (Selahattin Enis 2017, 277–280). This loyalty and compassion towards her husband are unusual for her character, but she still holds onto her sense of honesty in some way. Ultimately, instead of divorcing or abandoning him, she rescues İshak Effendi from their dilapidated house and brings him to her new apartment in Şişli. Although this makes İshak Effendi a 'cuckold', according to the narrator, it does not change Fikriye's faithfulness and conscience. This again highlights the conflict between the author's intentions and Fikriye's character within the novel's internal dynamics.

When evaluating *Everybody's Woman* in comparison to other novels of the 1920s, an epoch marking the transition from 'the national literature period' to 'the Republican

literature period', it shares similar characteristics only to the extent that its author's intentions are powerful. However, it differentiates itself in many ways, as demonstrated thus far. Many researchers, such as Jusdanis (1991) and Anderson (2006), have examined and revealed the significant role of literature and the press in the formation of national identity. In the Turkish case, as Dede (2015, 4) notes, the novel also plays a crucial role in nation-building: 'The novel was one of the most important tools of construction, between the years 1923–1938, which can be described as the nation-building period in Turkey'.

In societies similar to Turkey, which have undergone catastrophic transformation periods marked by internal political struggles (such as the proclamation of the first and second constitutional monarchies, the rise of the Young Turks and the Party of Union and Progress, and so on) and external conflicts (including the Balkan Wars and World War I), achieving a seamless national identity is a complex challenge. Literature played a significant role in orienting, shaping, and adopting the values, policies, and identities of the newly formed 'Turkish' society. So, the novels that fit the hegemonic discourse and dominant ideology of that time are listed as 'national' novels and become a part of the Turkish literary canon. Moreover, by continuously selecting, studying, and evaluating the novels accepted in this category, literary history and researchers in the field contributed to reproducing the rigid content of the literary canon as known today. As mentioned, Selahattin Enis started to produce novels, especially after 1920, and *Everybody's Woman* was serialised in 1925, so just mentioning some of the canonical novels of the same period gives us the opportunity to compare them across the themes and norms they seek to reinforce. For example, Reşat Nuri Güntekin serialised *Yeşil Gece* (*Green Night*) in 1928; Ercüment Ekrem, *Kan ve İman* (*Blood and Faith*) in 1922; Halide Edip *Ateşten Gömlek* (*Shirt of Flame*) in 1922 and *Vurun Kahpeye* (*Down with the Whore!*) in 1926; and Yakup Kadri, *Sodom ve Gomore* (*Sodom and Gomorrah*) in 1928. Since a detailed analysis of these novels exceeds the limit of this paper, I will just demarcate the common features of the canonical novels of the period. Central to them is the struggle against the occupying forces and the heroes and heroines who form part of the Turkish nationalist movement. But in *Everybody's Woman*, there is hardly any reference to the national war of independence (1918–1922). As stated before, the character Neyzen lands exceptionally sharp critiques against war profiteers and those collaborating with the occupying allied forces, whom Fikriye punishes by cheating them. But that's all. Time – at least narrative time – stops there. No national heroes or heroines, no struggle against allied forces, no great sacrifices. Naturally, these are but some of the many reasons underlying the exclusion of *Everybody's Woman* from the literary canon.

Another significant feature of the canonical novels is their heteronormative construction of male and female identities. In nationalist discourses, as Najmabadi (2013, 129) suggests, nations are constructed on the lines of brotherhood, and women are excluded from social contract. While the nation is imagined as a homeland for both men and women (or directly as 'the motherland'), according to Najmabadi, the modern state at a symbolic level becomes more masculinised (165). Especially from the perspective of sexual identity, nationalism aims at building a patriarchal and heteronormative society. Although male members of this community are bound to each other by brotherhood, there is no place for homoerotic desire, which is labelled immoral and unpatriotic (Sarıtaş 2018, 222–223). Moreover, homosexuality is regarded as a sign of corruption and moral degeneration in society. For example, in Yakup Kadri's *Sodom and Gomorrah*,

male homoeroticism is narrated as a sign of the general moral decadence of the occupation period (230). But when *Everybody's Woman* is compared with *Sodom and Gomorrah*, both its narration and characters appear to be queer, at odds with formal thinking.

On the other hand, as Holden (2003) points out, this notion of degeneration is common in postcolonial societies:

> Homosexuality and other non-normative sexualities became associated both with atavism – part of a decadent communal past so earnestly to be disavowed in the present – and also, paradoxically, with degeneration, as a marker of how the West had fallen away from the project of modernity. (313)

Although Ottoman society was spared the direct colonial rule that, for example, its Arab neighbours endured, the transition from Islamic empire to modern republic entailed a painful reckoning with the Ottoman past and the perceived encroachment of the Western powers. Indeed, the almost five years in which Istanbul was under effective allied occupation after World War I could be construed as a kind of 'colonial rule lite'.[6] Viewed this way, it is no coincidence that the number of novels narrating degeneration increased in this period:

> During the 1920s, it is evident that narratives highlighting moral decay, in which decadent characters become prominent actors. In novels like *Sodom and Gomorrah*, *Adulteress Women* and *Sözde Kızlar* (*Supposed Girls*), snobbish men and occasionally *femmes fatales* take on the role of seducers. Regardless, what we observe is the degradation of an entire community. (Sarıtaş 2018, 277)

While *Everybody's Woman* shares social criticism with these canonical novels, its silence about the national war of independence and the Republican period is reason enough for its exclusion from the canon. But there is more. The novel's stubborn rejection of the heteronormative rules forbidding homosexuality and homoerotic culture makes it even more impossible to be listed as canonical.

Conclusion

During our search on Turkish serial novel tradition, we have discovered hundreds of unknown novels and many novelists (Serdar and Tutumlı 2022). Selahattin Enis is not a completely forgotten novelist, but rather excluded, less mentioned, and unpreferred one. As a novelist of serial tradition, his works caught my attention, and when I first read *Everybody's Women* I was stunned by its plot, characters, use of language and courage to deal with the issues it covers. During the novel's publishing process I was continuously thinking about the reasons behind its dismissal from literary canon. It took a little while, but I can clearly admit that queer theory provided me great insights to understand and analyse both the novel and its exclusion process. This article is largely the result of this intellectual inquiry, and I hope it will contribute to the recognition of Selahattin Enis in western academic circles also.

Various factors and agents influence the formation of a literary canon. In the case of Ottoman/Turkish literature, as discussed in this paper, heteronormativity is one of the most significant determinants of what becomes part of the canon and what does not.

[6]While Istanbul was occupied, most of Anatolia during this period was under the control of the Turkish nationalist forces.

Selahattin Enis was a prolific and prominent novelist of his time, and *Everybody's Woman* was one of his popular novels, serialised in a popular daily newspaper. As a naturalist novelist, Selahattin Enis was critical of society, and in order to portray its degeneration, he aimed to create an unconventional female character, Fikriye, who possessed an excessive desire for sex.

However, as the story proceeds with each new instalment in the series, Fikriye, with her acts and performances, gains a kind of independence. That is to say, her actions resulted in a different outcome than the author intended, as she turns out to be a queer character. It is also true for other queer characters in the novel. Initially created to narrate the degeneration of late Ottoman society, they ended up bringing the vibrant homosocial culture of the period into the novel, as if they had infiltrated it and pushed against the boundaries of heteronormativity. While Selahattin Enis joined other novelists of his time, particularly in terms of nationalist ideology and dominant political tendencies, his narrative did not conform to canonical expectations. There were no references to the national struggle or the incoming Republican regime, creating significant gaps in representation. When you add the presence of queer characters to these 'politically unsatisfactory' features, it is hardly surprising that Selahattin Enis and his novels were excluded from literary history.

Notwithstanding this exclusion, I argue that *Everybody's Woman* uniquely reflects the queer culture of its time through its plot, characters, and narrative. Its existence serves as a reminder that Turkish novels are not entirely monologic, heteronormative, and blind to differences.

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